

G5 Fastest? Not in the UK

The Independent Television Commission (ITC) of the UK has banned the television commercial of Apple's 64-bit personal computer, the G5. ITC says the ad claims that the G5 is the world's fastest, most powerful personal computer, without sufficient evidence. Though Apple backed its findings in a white paper on its Web site, ITC says that the claim was based on the results of limited tests, in which the specifications of the computers were configured to give Apple the best results. Apple says the tests were done by Veritest, an independent lab, and that it fully disclosed the methods used in the tests to keep the process transparent. Apple has now modified its Web site, and is calling the G5 'the world's first 64-bit personal computer'.

snapshot

725 new software
flaws and **823**
worms &
hybrid threats
found in the third
quarter of **2003**

Source: www.iss.net

Web sites held ransom

The latest innovation in criminal ideas is online extortion. In Eastern Europe, criminals are using hacking threats to extort money from online business houses. The targets are businesses such as retailing, betting and payment providers, who depend on

online trade. A British online betting site was brought down, and it received a threat that it would happen again if it refused to pay. When it refused to do so, the site was brought down again. National Hi-Tech Crime Unit, the British agency responsible for tackling hi-tech crime, was then put on the case.



ILLUSTRATOR: Mahesh Benkar

Betting sites, especially, seem to be a favourite target—a dozen betting sites based in the US were also brought down and asked to pay \$50,000 a year to get respite from the attacks.

Collect bounties on virus writers

Microsoft has created an anti-virus reward programme to net people who release worms, viruses or other malicious code on the Internet. The initial \$5 million of funds will be used for monetary rewards to those who help in arresting such people. Residents of all countries will be eligible for these rewards.

As the first step of this program, Microsoft has announced a reward of a quarter of a million dollars to anyone who helps finding the per-

son responsible for the MSBlast.A worm. Although arrests for the B and C variants have been made, the person responsible for the original worm is still unknown. MSBlast was designed to attack Microsoft's Windows Update Web site. The second reward has been announced for information resulting in the arrest of the person responsible for the Sobig virus. Messages from Sobig's B and C variants appear as if they're from Microsoft, and attack individual PCs.



Spam

Smart anti-spam

SmartScreen—a junk-e-mail filtering technology—uses an algorithm based on probability to determine spam. The database that this technology uses consists of feedback from users who volunteered to review e-mails to identify spam. An e-mail arriving at Microsoft's e-mail server, or a client running SmartScreen technology, is studied for the occurrence and pattern of more than 500,000 words to distinguish spam from legitimate e-mails. This technology has already been incorporated into Outlook 2003, MSN 8 and Hotmail, and will be available in other products as well.

Circumventing spam

AT&T has received a patent for a technique that circumvents a junk mail filter that uses duplicate detection to identify spam. To circumvent the filter, the e-mail addresses are grouped in different sub-lists and a set of different messages is created. Each sub-list is sent a different e-mail message, thus rendering duplicate detection redundant. A&T is expected to use this patent to sue spammers who use such techniques, thus helping to reduce spam.

■ Intel plans to make a huge investment in supercomputing research and develop the fastest supercomputer using Itanium 2

